

pantry that I had high hopes for in the store, but in real life I was too busy to make. Now, I walk into my kitchen, let my fridge and pantry tell me what to make, write a list for the rest, and no one in my house has to ask me “What’s for dinner?”

If you’ve ever tried meal planning and been unsuccessful, you may be trying to fit a round peg in a square hole. Don’t worry, there’s a space that fits for you in meal planning. There are two types of meal planners: Jens and Jills.

Some people, like Jen, love planning. We want to create the perfect meal plan every week with healthy meals. We want variety and the best utilization of every ingredient. The pro for Jens is that meal planning comes naturally to you. The con is that you often don’t follow through with your perfect meal plan because life isn’t perfect. We don’t live in a vacuum. You may have planned for a forty-five-minute meal on Wednesday, but by the time it rolls around, you only have the energy for a fifteen-minute meal, but you made that one on Monday. Your goal is to give up having the best meal plan and pursue a realistic meal plan. Look at your week and be honest about the days you have time and energy and the days you don’t. And know that it’s totally okay if seven out of seven are “no time, no energy” days. Those seasons happen, especially with kids. Prioritize short ingredient lists, little to no prep time, and as few dishes as possible. Every week I do some version of a one-pot chicken and rice, a freezer meal (sometimes prepared in advance by me, sometimes store-bought), and a salad. After years of cooking, those are dishes I’ve found that I’ll say yes to before saying yes to takeout. Your goal is to find yours.

If you’re not a planner, meal planning can still be for you, just in a different way. Other people, like Jill, want flexibility. Maybe you travel a lot or you don’t want to tie your schedule down to a recipe in case something else comes up. Or you love to cook and want the freedom to try new ingredients. The idea of a rigid meal plan and grocery list may sound horrible to you. Or at best unrealistic. The solution for you is an options list. Each week Jill takes inventory of what she already has on hand and meal options that can be made with those ingredients. Because she and Eric both work from home, this plan includes a list of four or five lunch options and four or five dinner options. When mealtimes roll around, she uses this like a menu and decides what sounds good in that moment. Since these options